The Original Avengers Roster

Volume 03 — locked in on top of Volumes 01 and 02. This roster follows the comics exactly: who formed the team, in what order, and who joined later.

The Founding Five — *The Avengers* #1 (September 1963)

Founder	Character	First comics appearance	Actor
Iron Man	Tony Stark	*Tales of Suspense* #39 (Mar 1963)	Fictional
Thor	Thor, daughter of Odin	*Journey into Mystery* #83 (Aug 1962)	Fictional, female
Hulk	Bruce Banner	*The Incredible Hulk* #1 (May 1962)	Fictional
Ant-Man	Hank Pym	*Tales to Astonish* #27 (Jan 1962)	Fictional
Wasp	Janet van Dyne	*Tales to Astonish* #44 (June 1963)	Fictional

- **Why they assemble:** Loki tricks the Hulk into a rampage to lure Thor. Iron Man, Ant-Man and Wasp answer the call, and all five end up fighting Loki together.
- **Who names them:** Janet van Dyne, who says the team should have "a colorful name, like... the Avengers!" Keep that line.
- **Hulk leaves almost at once** (*Avengers* #2, November 1963). Nobody trusts him, so he quits, and in issue #3 he fights the team alongside Namor. That gives the shared universe a former founder as a threat right from the start.

The Honorary Founder — *The Avengers* #4 (March 1964)

Member	Character	First comics appearance	Actor
Captain America	Steve Rogers	*Captain America Comics* #1 (Mar 1941)	Fictional

The Avengers find Steve Rogers frozen in the Arctic ice and revive him. He takes the Hulk's place, becomes the team's leader and its moral center, and is honored as a founding member ever after. His grief over Bucky Barnes, who he believes died in 1945, drives his story, which sets up the Winter Soldier reveal.

The Second Lineup — "Cap's Kooky Quartet", *The Avengers* #16 (May 1965)

Member	Character	First comics appearance	Actor
Captain America	Steve Rogers (leader)	—	Fictional
Hawkeye	Claire Barton	*Tales of Suspense* #57 (Sept 1964)	Fictional, female
Scarlet Witch	Wanda Maximoff	*X-Men* #4 (Mar 1964)	Fictional
Quicksilver	Pietro Maximoff	*X-Men* #4 (Mar 1964)	Aaron Taylor-Johnson (born June 13, 1990; 15 today)

Iron Man, Thor, Ant-Man and Wasp step away from the team, and the Avengers become three reformed villains led by a man out of time. This is the first big proof that being an Avenger is about earning redemption, not having the most power.

Rights note (2006): Fox and Marvel both have a claim on Wanda and Pietro. Under the Rights Reservation Doctrine, their full comics history, including their mutant origin and their father, Magneto, is canon in the Universe Bible. On screen they appear only in ways the contracts allow until those rights are cleared. In the real-world story, this is a legal fight between Marvel and Fox.

Black Widow — Comic-Accurate Path

- She first appears in *Tales of Suspense* #52 (April 1964) as a Soviet spy sent against **Iron Man**.
- She works alongside Hawkeye, defects from the Soviet Union, and becomes an ally of the team and a S.H.I.E.L.D. agent. She officially joins the Avengers in *The Avengers* #111 (May 1973).
- **In the MCU,** she starts as an antagonist in the Iron Man films, defects, and earns her place on the team. She is **not** a founder.

How This Lands on Screen

Film	Roster moment
Phase One solo films	*Iron Man* (2008), *The Incredible Hulk* (2008), ***Ant-Man* (2009)** introducing Hank Pym and Janet van Dyne, *Thor* (2011), and *Captain America: The First Avenger* (2011), which ends with Steve frozen in the ice.
The Avengers (May 4, 2012)	Loki manipulates the Hulk and the five founders assemble. Janet names the team. They find Captain America in the ice in the third act, and the Hulk walks away at the end.
Phase Two	Captain America leads the Avengers. Black Widow, an antagonist in the Iron Man films, defects.
Avengers: Age of Ultron (May 1, 2015)	"The Old Order Changeth": the founders step away and Cap's Kooky Quartet takes over (Cap, Claire Barton, Wanda, Pietro).

Release titles and dates follow the official slate in Volume 04.